Deliverable 6 — IELTS Preparation Plan

Prepared 15 October 2026 for Bhumika Veerapura Siddagangappa · Goal: **IELTS Academic 7.0 overall, no band below 6.5**, with the score in hand by early December 2026 · Budget: about ₹20,000 all-in

> **The short version.** Take a free diagnostic mock this weekend. Book the **computer-delivered IELTS Academic** with IDP for **14–28 November 2026**. Prepare for 4–5 weeks at about 12–15 hours a week, using mostly free official material, two Cambridge books (under ₹500 each) and free YouTube channels. Results take 2–5 days, so the score is ready for the Galway/UL/DCU applications in early December, with time for a retake in December–January if one band falls short.

1. What the universities require

University / programme	Minimum IELTS Academic	Our target
University of Galway — MSc International Accounting & Analytics	6.5 overall, no band below 6.0	**7.0 / no band < 6.5**
University of Limerick — MSc Insurance & Risk Management	6.5 overall, no band below 6.0	7.0 / 6.5
DCU — MSc International Accounting & Business	6.5 overall, minimum 6.0 in each band	7.0 / 6.5
Trinity College Dublin — MSc Operations & Supply Chain	6.5 overall, no band below 6.0	7.0 / 6.5
GOI-IES scholarship and the visa file	No fixed band, but a strong score helps both	7.0+

Why aim for 7.0 instead of 6.5: a 6.5 just meets the minimum, so one weak band (usually Writing) means a conditional offer and a retake. A 7.0 removes that risk and looks stronger for the merit scholarships and GOI-IES.

Which test: take **IELTS Academic**, *not* General Training. General Training is for migration and is **not accepted** for university admission. "IELTS for UKVI" is not needed for Ireland either.

2. Fees and logistics (India, 2026)

Item	Cost	Notes
IELTS Academic (computer or paper)	**₹19,000**	Fee since 1 April 2026. **IDP is the only IELTS provider in India**, so book on *ielts.idp.com/india* and nowhere else. Confirm the price at checkout.
One Skill Retake (if one band falls short)	≈ ₹12,000–₹12,650	Available only after a computer-delivered test. **Ask each university in writing whether it accepts One Skill Retake before relying on it.** Otherwise retake the full test (₹19,000).
Date transfer / cancellation	Fees and deductions apply	Transfers need advance notice. Choose the date carefully.
Sending results to universities	Electronic delivery to institutions through IDP	Add Galway, UL, DCU and Trinity as recipients. Score validity is **2 years** (a Nov 2026 test is valid until Nov 2028).

Computer-delivered vs paper: choose computer-delivered.

- Results arrive in **about 2–5 days** instead of about 13 for paper. This is what makes the December application window work.
- There are more test dates in Bengaluru, often several a week.
- She types every day at work, so typing Writing answers is faster and easier to edit than handwriting, and the on-screen word count prevents under-length answers.

- One Skill Retake is only available after the computer test.
- The Speaking test is face-to-face with an examiner in both formats, sometimes on a different day.

The name must match the passport. When booking, enter **Given name: BHUMIKA** and **Surname: VEERAPURA SIDDAGANGAPPA**, exactly as on the passport, and bring **the same passport** on test day. A mismatch between the test report and the passport can cause admission and visa problems.

3. The timeline (how fast is realistic)

She uses English every day in corporate work at Amazon and EY and studied in English, so she is probably already in the 6.0–7.0 range. The plan is about **learning the test format**, not learning English from scratch.

Dates	Step	Detail
Sat 17 – Sun 18 Oct	**Diagnostic mock** (free)	One full timed Academic test (Listening, Reading, Writing) from the free British Council *IELTS Ready* account or the IDP free practice tests. Self-score Listening and Reading with the answer key. Score Writing against the public band descriptors (see §6).
Mon 19 Oct	**Book the test** based on the diagnostic	**Diagnostic ≥ 6.5 everywhere:** book for **14–21 November** (4 weeks of prep). **Any band at 5.5–6.0:** book for **25–28 November** (5–6 weeks).
19 Oct – test day	Weekly plan (§4)	12–15 hours a week: about 1 hour on weekday mornings or evenings, 3–4 hours on Saturday and Sunday
Test day + 2–5 days	Results	Upload to the Galway/UL/DCU portals the same day. Applications can be submitted *before* the score arrives, marked "IELTS scheduled".
If short by one band	One Skill Retake (if accepted) or a full retake in **Dec 2026 – Jan 2027**	Offers will be conditional on the score, so this is still well before the March loan and visa steps

Do not book a date later than early December. A late score delays offers, which then delays the GOI-IES application (an offer is needed to apply) and the loan sanction.

4. Five-week study plan (≈ 65 hours)

Week	Focus	What to do
1 (19–25 Oct): format and baseline	Understand every question type	Watch one "format overview" video per module (§5). Do **Cambridge IELTS Academic Test 1** under timed conditions. Make an error log (a notebook or spreadsheet with the question type, why it was wrong, and the fix).
2 (26 Oct – 1 Nov): Reading and Listening technique	Speed and accuracy	Reading: about 20 minutes per passage. Practise True/False/Not Given, Matching Headings and Sentence Completion. Listening: spelling of numbers, dates and names; map/plan labelling. Do 2 sections of each every day.
3 (2–8 Nov): Writing	Usually the band that pulls Indian candidates below 7	**Task 1** (graphs, tables, processes): an overview sentence, key trends and comparisons, no opinions, 150+ words in 20 minutes. Her analyst work makes this natural. **Task 2** (essay): a clear position, 4–5 paragraphs, 260–290 words in 40 minutes. Write **5 Task 2 essays and 4 Task 1 reports**, then compare each with band-7/8 model answers.
4 (9–15 Nov): Speaking and full mocks	Fluency and coherence	Record answers on the phone every day: Part 1 (personal questions), Part 2 (a 2-minute talk on a cue card; practise 15 common cue-card topics), Part 3 (discussion). Listen back for fillers, pauses and repeated words. Do **two full mock tests** on the weekend.

Week	Focus	What to do
5 (16–22 Nov): polish and test week	Exam conditions	One full mock at the same time of day as the real test. Light review of the error log only. **No new material in the last 48 hours.** Sleep well the night before.

Daily rhythm on weekdays (about 60–75 minutes): 15 minutes of listening practice on the commute, 30 minutes of reading or writing, 15 minutes of speaking recording, 5 minutes updating the error log.

5. Study materials — free or under ₹500

Free official material (start here)

Resource	What it gives	Where
British Council *IELTS Ready* — free Member account	Free mock tests and speaking practice. Works from India, no booking needed.	takeielts.britishcouncil.org → *Prepare* → IELTS Ready
IDP free IELTS preparation	Free practice tests, preparation webinars and *IELTS Masterclass* sessions. Extra prep resources become available after booking.	ielts.idp.com/india → *Prepare*
ielts.org official sample questions	Real-format sample questions for all four modules	ielts.org → *Prepare for your test*
Official band descriptors (PDF)	The exact criteria examiners use for Writing and Speaking. Read them and self-score against them.	ielts.org (search "band descriptors")
British Council LearnEnglish	Free grammar and vocabulary practice	learnenglish.britishcouncil.org

Free YouTube channels (pick 2, don't binge)

Channel	Best for
IELTS Official / IDP IELTS	Format walkthroughs and test-day guidance from the test owners
E2 IELTS (E2 Language)	Clear strategies for every question type, especially Writing Task 1 and Task 2 structure
IELTS Liz (also ieltsliz.com, free)	Reading and Listening tips and many model answers
IELTS Advantage (Chris Pell)	Writing Task 2 planning, which is the highest-impact skill for a 7.0
Keith O'Hare — IELTS Daily	Speaking: natural fluency, Part 2 cue cards, mock interviews
ielts-simon.com (website, free)	Short, clean band-8/9 model essays written by an ex-examiner

Under ₹500

Item	Approx. cost	Why
Cambridge IELTS Academic 19 (Cambridge University Press, Indian edition)	≈ ₹450–₹600 new; under ₹500 on discount or second-hand	**Authentic past papers** (4 full tests with audio and answer keys). This is the single most important paid resource.
Cambridge IELTS Academic 18 (optional second book)	≈ ₹450–₹600	4 more authentic tests for weeks 4–5
One Udemy IELTS course on sale (e.g. *IELTS Band 7+ Complete Prep Course*)	₹399–₹499 during the frequent Udemy sales	Structured video lessons if she prefers a course to scattered YouTube. Only buy at the sale price.

Avoid expensive coaching packages (₹8,000–₹25,000). For a working professional who already uses English at work, authentic past papers and disciplined self-study give the same result. If Writing stays at 6.0 after week 3, a short paid **writing-correction** package (5–10 essays marked by a trained tutor) is the one paid add-on worth considering.

Using an AI assistant for feedback: paste the essay together with the official Writing band descriptors and ask for a band estimate *and* the specific sentences to fix. This is useful for spotting patterns, but AI band estimates can be generous, so treat them as practice feedback, not a prediction.

6. Module strategies for a 7.0

Listening (30 minutes + 2 minutes of checking on the computer test).

- Read the questions *before* each section plays and underline the answer type (number, name, noun).
- Spelling and plural "s" are marked strictly.
- A 7.0 needs about **30/40**.

Reading (60 minutes, 3 passages, no extra transfer time).

- Skim each passage for 2 minutes, then answer the questions in order.
- *Not Given* means the text does not say. Do not infer.
- Never spend more than 20 minutes on one passage. A 7.0 needs about **30/40** on Academic.

Writing (60 minutes). This is the band most likely to decide the result.

- **Do Task 2 first** (40 minutes). It carries twice the weight of Task 1.
- **Task 2 structure:** introduction (paraphrase the question + a clear position) → two body paragraphs (one idea each, explanation + example) → conclusion. Avoid memorised phrases and over-complex vocabulary; examiners reward accuracy and clear linking.
- **Task 1:** always include an **overview** of the main trends. Leaving it out caps the score at about 5–6 for Task Achievement.
- On the computer test, watch the word counter: Task 1 at least 150 words, Task 2 at least 250.

Speaking (11–14 minutes, face-to-face).

- Answer in 2–3 sentences in Part 1 and extend naturally.
- In Part 2, use the 1 minute of preparation to note 4–5 keywords (not sentences) and speak for the full 2 minutes.
- In Part 3, give opinions with reasons and examples. Her workplace experience is useful material for topics like technology, work and education.
- Fluency and natural pronunciation matter more than a "foreign" accent. It is fine to say "That's an interesting question, let me think...".

7. Test-day checklist

- ☐ **Original passport**, the same one used for booking: *BHUMIKA VEERAPURA SIDDAGANGAPPA*
- ☐ Arrive **30–45 minutes early** at the IDP centre (Bengaluru). Photo and biometrics are taken on arrival.
- ☐ Only water in a clear bottle is allowed. Everything else goes in the locker.
- ☐ Speaking-test time confirmed (it may be on a different day or slot)
- ☐ After the test: check the results online on day 2–5, then send the electronic results to the universities straight away and upload the Test Report Form to each portal

8. How this fits the master timeline

Master-timeline step	Dependency on IELTS
Galway / UL submissions by 20–25 Nov (Deliverable 5)	Can be submitted with "IELTS scheduled"; upload the score in early December
DCU by 30 Nov, Trinity by 15 Dec	Ideally submitted with the score in hand
Offers in January	A conditional offer becomes unconditional once the score is uploaded
GOI-IES in Jan–Mar	Needs the offer, so the IELTS score must not be late
Visa in late May – June	The Test Report Form goes in the visa pack, and it stays valid until Nov 2028

Sources checked October 2026: IDP IELTS India (booking, fees, results), British Council *IELTS Ready*, ielts.org (format, sample questions, band descriptors), and the university English-language requirement pages for Galway, UL, DCU and Trinity. Fees and university requirements can change, so confirm on the official pages at booking and before applying.